

JUSSAWALLA'S PIECES **RECORD THE FLEETING MOMENTS** THAT ADD BOTH BEAUTY AND HORROR TO MUMBAI

Jussawalla writes about the annual exodus when the city's cobblers and fruit sellers and Mafco stall assistants pack up and leave for their "native places"; about the change of light after men on a scaffolding hang up a jute curtain outside his window; about the drummers who are part of the Ganpati processions and who seem to "erupt out of the earth just to take part in the celebrations, and to sink back into the earth once the celebrations are over".

This is like a lucky dip: you never know what you will come up with. Some pieces can feel dated and random. But others remain fresh, funny and a reminder that some things—like the disappearing waiters of posh clubs or the "De daan, de daan" cry after an eclipse—are here to stay.

—Shabnam Minwalla

the Silver Market', the author witnesses an Indian protester being shot dead in Chandni Chowk; later, he dines with a soldier—"from an industrial slum near Liverpool"—who "had been in the party that had done the shooting."

In the second book, Menen reads the Upanishads after the death of his parents. The titular space within the heart, the void inside the onion, is "only an empty space to be used as a post for observation". Menen writes about sex and the spirit, the Gita, Rigveda, Descartes and the Bloomsbury set with wicked humour and in tone-perfect prose. The writing voice is involved yet maintains an arm's distance—it's both participant and observer. "The best way to stop thinking about yourself is to talk about yourself, and that is why so many people do it... When you know yourself for what you are—or what the world has made of you—you prefer to shut up about it." ■

—Palash Krishna Mehrotra

A SINGULAR ARTIST

A comprehensive study of conceptual artist **Mithu Sen**, *Unmyth* is as stimulating as her art

Is it possible for an artist monograph to feel like a live art performance? Capturing the essence of Mithu Sen's work—installations, moving images, sculptures, word art, performances, and drawings—over two decades, *Unmyth: Works and Worlds of Mithu Sen* is as untameable as her practice itself.



UNMYTH: WORKS AND WORLDS OF MITHU SEN
Edited by Irina Aristarkhova
MAPIN
₹3,500; 364 pages

It's also in line with Sen's ethos behind "Unlanguage," a creation where she uses nonsensical phrases and incorrect syntax as an act of dismantling the conventional rules of language. The first comprehensive study of the artist's wide-ranging oeuvre, *Unmyth* is thoughtfully edited by scholar-writer Irina Aristarkhova and innovatively designed by Anusha Yadav. Along with being an archive, the intention is to underline the individuality of Sen's practice, which provokes us to envision new worlds

***WHEN* ONE SCANS THE QR CODES IN THE BOOK, SEN'S WORK UNFOLDS IN REAL TIME**

built around negotiating ideas of lingual anarchy, mything, 'un'mything and postmything, radical hospitality, 'un'taboo sexuality, and 'un'monolith identity. It is what Sen describes as "a testament to 25 years of love and playbour (play + labour)."

There are QR codes inserted within the book which when scanned reveal work that unfolds in real time.

The book also features contributions from curators, academics, and critics who have engaged with Sen's work over the years. Yet, the book's breathless centrepiece is the 'Fictional Interview' by Sen herself. The questions asked resemble some of the inquiries posed at her practice over the years. But in form and scope, they replicate the playful provocation that makes Mithu Sen truly singular. ■

—Poulomi Das